

PEOPLE'S GOVERNOR:
Thakur in one of the
janata darshans



RAJ BHAVAN RAJ

With Karnataka set for a long stint of President's rule, Rameshwar Thakur adopts a proactive role, taking over the functions of the chief minister and even organising janata darshans

■ **By Stephen David**

In Bangalore, the imposing granite edifice—Vidhana Soudha—which houses the office of the Karnataka chief minister, and the Raj Bhavan—the governor's mansion—are about 300 m apart, but both the buildings bear the same nameplate: Rameshwar Thakur, chartered accountant, former professor at Delhi University and an ex-Union minister.

Thakur is perhaps the only governor in the state in more than three decades to don the dual responsibilities of chief minister and Governor as the Centre imposed President's rule on October 10, a week after the JD(S) led by H.D. Kumaraswamy refused to hand over power to its coalition partner BJP as per the February 2006 pact.

Karnataka came under a year-long President's rule for the first time in

March 1971 with the exit of Congress chief minister Veerendra Patil. The second time was for 52 days after chief minister Devaraj Urs resigned in December 1977 revolting against the then Congress president Indira Gandhi. For the third time it was under President's rule in 1989 from April to November when Janata Dal chief minister S.R. Bommai was dismissed when his party lost majority in the lower house following a revolt.

With the Assembly in suspended animation, and the governor yet to be assigned advisors, a section of the JD-S is knocking at the doors of the Congress to cobble up a coalition government. However, Thakur shows no signs of yielding. On the con-

trary, he is relishing power.

On October 12, Thakur, a Gandhi family loyalist, who had served as minister in both Rajiv Gandhi and Narasimha Rao governments, created a flutter when he went up to the third floor office and plonked himself in the chief minister's chair. With Chief Secretary P.B. Mahishi and Thakur's Secretary Sharada Subramaniam, an

Indian Accounts and Audit Service officer, on hand to assist him, the governor quickly got down to business by reviewing the functioning of key departments including home, health, energy, agriculture, water resources and public works and gave a pep talk to senior IAS and service officials.

Though the JD(S) is knocking on the Congress's doors to cobble up a government, Thakur shows no signs of yielding.